

Chapter One

EN source - fantasy chapter (F2 NER LLM benchmark)

The Withering had begun at the edge of the Whispering Marsh, where the pale reeds bowed even when there was no wind. Kestra watched it from the tower of Ravenwood Manor and felt the old curse breathe, slow and patient, beneath the ground. Her grandmother had told her that the Withering spared no root and no promise, and that only the Order of the Pale Hand had ever slowed it.

'You should not stand so close to the window,' said Dain from the doorway. He was the last steward of the Order of the Pale Hand, and he carried the Black Key on a chain of cold iron. 'The marsh remembers those who watch it.'

'Let it remember,' Kestra answered. She turned from the window and took the lamp from the table. Somewhere below, the Wyrmling that slept beneath the manor shifted in its sleep, and the foundation stones sang a low broken note.

They went down through the galleries, past the portraits of the stewards of Ravenwood Manor, and out into the yard where the wyrmlings nested in the old well. The wyrmlings were small and blind and they fled from the lamplight, but Kestra knew their mother was near. The Wyrmling of the marsh was the last of its kind in the northern valleys, and it had guarded the manor since before the Order of the Pale Hand had built its first chapter house.

At the gate stood Sorrel, the hedge-witch of Thornbury, wrapped in a cloak the colour of wet bark. She had walked three days from the village of Thornbury to warn them. 'The curse is awake,' she said. 'The Withering has taken the mill and the bridge, and by morning it will have the orchard. The Order of the Pale Hand must open the Vault beneath the chapel.'

Dain lifted the Black Key so that its sigil caught the lamplight. 'The Vault has been sealed for a hundred years,' he said. 'What the key opens, the key also locks behind us.'

'Then we go down together,' said Kestra. And far below them, patient as the dark, the Withering reached through the soil and took the first apple tree.